projects and arising from which a controversy seems to have emerged'. The chief minister agreed to meet him three days later.

The next day, Tata Tea released quarter-page advertisements in the country's leading dailies. It conveyed a strong and emotionally appealing message, carefully articulated the views of the group and refuted all the allegations of its links with terror outfits. Ratan personally vetted the advertisement, which went under his signature.

It unequivocally stated that 'Tata Tea has not made any payments to ULFA'. The group 'steadfastly refused to yield to extortionist pressures', contributed substantially to the 'needs of the people' especially in the health sector, extended a 'helping and caring hand that would provide a healing touch' and was 'committed to the People's Welfare and the Nation's Integrity', it said. At the same time, it stressed that 'it is unfair to malign a company … just because it has unwittingly reimbursed the medical expenses of a person who is now suspected of having links with terrorists'.

The release once again clarified that the meetings that the group officials had with ULFA were not held clandestinely, but on the advice of the Central government and the IB. Through this assertion, the group tried to meet the state government's pointed accusations of not having kept the authorities in the loop. Tata Tea further claimed that the Central government had itself sanctioned the controversial Medical Aid scheme.

But there was no one who would independently corroborate the Tata version. The only confirmation came some twenty-three years later when I interviewed Rattan Sehgal. Speaking on record, he said that the Tatas did nothing 'without consulting the Central government'.

On 15 September, Ratan met with Union Home Minister Indrajit Gupta and Home Secretary Padmanabhaiah and said that the Assam DGP's criticism of the group was misplaced. He told the home minister that the dubbing of the 'Tata Group as anti-national' on 'insufficient ground' had 'seriously tarnished' its image. Throughout the history of the group, if anything, it had given national goals primacy. He was, however, ambiguous about whether some Tata Tea officials had known of 'Bonti Baruah['s]' true identity. He stated, 'Certainly [the] senior management of Tatas had no knowledge about the identity of the persons', a version that was independently supported by the state's former intelligence chief in an interview to me.